

7.4 Shapes

Try drawing a perfect circle using the Pen tool. Exasperating, isn't it? This was a painful flaw in Photoshop before version 5.5. Thankfully, now you can create simple vector shapes like circles, rectangles and polygons using the Shape Tool (U) .

When you select the Shape tool, you can choose to create Shape Layers, paths or raster shapes from the option bar. Your best bet is the Shape Layer—it creates a new layer filled with the foreground colour, and a path that you can edit later on as well.



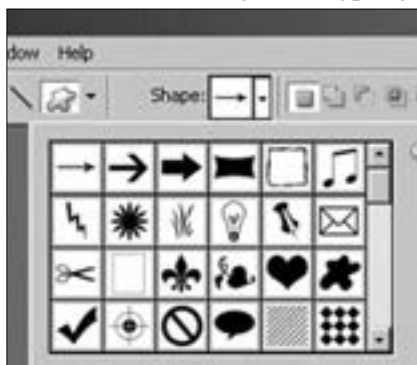
A New Shape Layer is created for each shape

You can also combine shapes in the same shape layer by choosing the Add to Path Area button  in the option bar.

Drawing shapes on your image is just like drawing a selection with the marquee tool—even the keyboard shortcuts that we mentioned in Chapter 3 apply here.

Just like type layers, you can transform and add layer styles to shape layers without having to rasterize them. And just like type layers, you will have to rasterize them to paint or apply filters to them.

To change the colour of the Shape layer, double-click on its thumbnail in the Layers Palette—the colour picker will come up, and you can choose the colour you want.



Select Custom Shape from the option bar to choose from a variety of cool shapes